

Fishing for TROUBLE

As mercury contamination reaches danger levels in West Bengal and experts warn of health problems, the state's favourite food comes under the scanner



BRINGING A CATCH HOME IN THE DIGHA AND MANDARMANI BELT

KAUSHIK

By Abhijit Dasgupta

Rampant industrialisation will not go down well with the fish-lovers of West Bengal if People for the Ethical Treatment of Animals (PETA) reports are to be believed. Fish is served at every Bengali festival and the way it is consumed by the community across the world leaves no doubt that perhaps only the rosogulla and football can come close to be dubbed as even distant competition. But the popular varieties of fish have been reported to be contaminated both in water and when on sale in the markets. Worse, the state Government is yet to respond to the findings and has put the blame on heavy industry for the contamination.

India is the third-largest producer of fish globally with an annual production of 6.3 million tonnes. In

2002-2003 alone, West Bengal earned Rs 600 crore in foreign exchange from its fish production. PETA, along with Disha and Toxins Link, both non-governmental organisations, carried out a survey at Kolkata's top five fish retail markets and confirmed that more than 60 per cent of the production was contaminated, which included the popular Hilsa, Tangra and Bhetki. The permissible limit of mercury intake set by the US Environment Protection Agency for a 50-kg human body is five microgram, while the reports

said that the fish intake in West Bengal is as high as a kilogram a week, which would mean mercury intake is way above the danger mark. "The danger cannot be overestimated and obviously, the lesser the body weight, the greater the danger. Children are the worst sufferers because the provisional tolerable weekly intake is proportional to the weight of the consumer, the intake quantity and the degree of contamination," says Dr Santanu Chacreverti, environment activist associated with Disha.

And it is Hilsa, one of the most

“We are conducting routine tests but could not find anything alarming. However, we welcome the PETA initiative.”

RACHPAL KAHLOL

PRINCIPAL SECRETARY, FISHERIES



FISH SELLERS ARE UNWILLING TO WARN CUSTOMERS ABOUT THE CONTAMINATION.